English A · Questions and answers

CHAPTER 11

The Dear Departed - Question Answers

> **Q.1: What do the actions and words of Mrs. Slater and Mrs. Jordan reveal about their true motivations? How do these motivations influence their behaviour throughout the play?**

Ans: Mrs. Slater and Mrs. Jordan are **greedy** and **selfish**. They care more about their father's **belongings** than his memory. Each wants to get his things **before the other sister**. They do not show **sorrow** or **love**. They start **dividing his property** at once. This shows that **personal gain** matters more to them than **family love**.

> **Q.2: How does the conflict over Mr. Merryweather's possessions drive the plot of the play? What does this conflict reveal about the characters' values and priorities?**

Ans: The **fight over the belongings** moves the story forward. The sisters argue over his **furniture, clothes, and clock**, so the play is both **funny** and **sad**. This shows that the characters value **money and property** more than **love or morals**. Their priorities are **materialistic**, and **greed** destroys respect in the family.

> **Q.3: In what ways does Stanley Houghton use satire to criticize family dynamics and social values in the play? How effective is this approach in conveying his message?**

Ans: Houghton uses **satire** and light **humour** to show **greed**, **hypocrisy**, and lack of **real love** in families. The characters pretend to be moral but only care about **wealth and status**. Funny situations and clever dialogue **expose their fake behaviour**. This is **effective** because it entertains the audience and also makes them **think**.

> **Q.4: How does the play challenge the traditional idea of family, unity, and affection? What does The Dear Departed suggest about the nature of family ties when material wealth is involved?**

Ans: The play challenges the idea of a **loving, united family**. The daughters **compete for things** instead of caring for their father. It shows that when **wealth** becomes more important, **family ties become weak**. Relationships built on **greed** cannot last. Real unity needs **love and respect**.

> **Q.5: What role does the clock on the mantelpiece play in the story? How might it symbolize the characters' attitude towards time, routine, or even inheritance?**

Ans: The clock is an important **symbol**. It stands for **time, death, and the passing of generations**. It also shows their **greed**, because they fight over it instead of **mourning**. It reminds us that **time keeps moving** and people waste it chasing **material things**.

> **Q.6: How does Victoria's character differ from the adults around her? What does her perspective tell us about the younger generation's view of the family's behaviour?**

Ans: Victoria is **innocent, honest, and caring**, while the adults are **greedy and selfish**. Through her eyes, we see how **shameful** their behaviour is. She represents the **younger generation**, which can see **moral corruption**. It values **truth, respect, and kindness** more than possessions.

> **Q.7: How do the characters display hypocrisy throughout the play? What are some examples where their words contradict their actions?**

Ans: The characters are **hypocrites**. They wear **mourning clothes** to impress others, but they are **not truly sad**. They do not even **see their father's body**. Instead, they **drink tea** and plan to **divide his property**. Their **words of grief** contradict their **selfish actions**.

> **Q.8: How does the setting of the play\u2014a single, confined living room\u2014affect the way the characters interact with each other? What might this confined space suggest about the nature of their relationships?**

Ans: The play happens in **one small living room**, so the characters must stay **close** and face each other. This increases **tension** and makes their **greed and fake emotions** easy to see. The small space also shows their **narrow minds**. They live close together, but their hearts are **distant** and full of **jealousy**.

> **Q.9: How does Stanley Houghton organize the sequence of events in The Dear Departed to build tension and reveal the characters' true motives?**

Ans: Houghton builds tension **step by step**. At first, the sisters show **fake sadness** and speak politely. Slowly, their **greed and rivalry** become clear. The change from **false mourning** to **open fighting** creates tension and humour. It shows how easily **family love disappears** when **money** is involved.

> **Q.10: How do the themes of The Dear Departed remain relevant in modern society? Can you think of contemporary examples where materialism impacts family relationships in a similar way?**

Ans: The themes are still **relevant today**. Many families fight over **property and inheritance** after a parent's death. Some children **neglect their parents** for wealth or comfort. Houghton warns that **materialism destroys family values**. True happiness comes from **love and care**, not money.